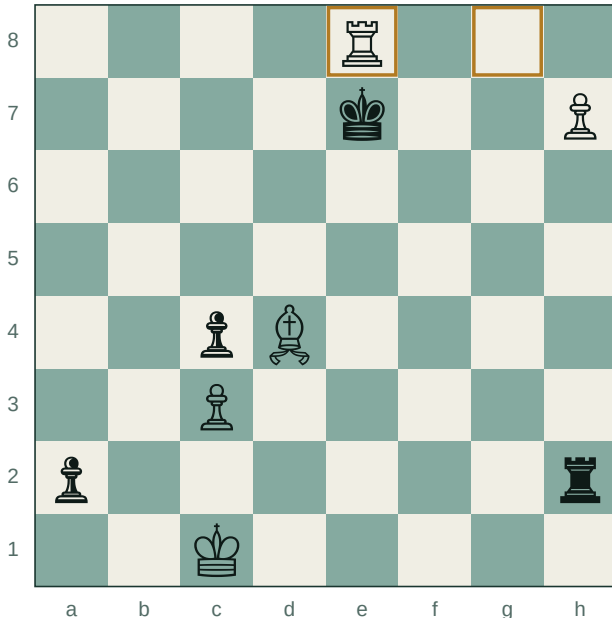


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 51

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 51.Re8+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

51...Kxe8 52. h8=R+ Rxh8

51...Kxe8 The king captures the rook on e8. Recorded reply: **52.h8=R+**.

52...Rxh8 The rook captures the rook on h8.

At the end, nominal material is White 4 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -3 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on c1. Geometrically undefended: rook on e8. Check for tactical protection.